



Plans for Ohio River Trail extend to Ohio

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By Bob Podurgiel

In 2009, Vincent Troia wanted to ride his bike on a local trail, but first he had to make a choice.

He could either travel west to the Rail to Trail in Lisbon, Ohio, or east to the Montour Trail, the 46-mile trail connecting Moon and Clairton.

“I was about halfway between the two and thought it would be nice if we could connect the trails,” he said.

Mr. Troia, a Monaca optometrist, talked with Mario Leone Jr., the Monaca manager, who liked the idea of connecting the two trails.

The meeting led Mr. Troia to form the Ohio River Trail Council, a volunteer-based nonprofit dedicated to building a new trail in Pennsylvania through Beaver County.

Since then, thousands of volunteer hours have been devoted to planning, grant writing and educating the public about the potential benefits of the trail. Now, the project is moving forward.

The Ohio River Trail Council hosted an open house May 1 at the Community College of Beaver County in Monaca to present the latest engineering drawings and plans for the proposed 41-mile Ohio River Trail that will thread its way through 21 communities along the Ohio River in Beaver County to the Ohio-Pennsylvania border.

Maps, drawings and videos of the proposed trail were available at the learning resource center on the community college campus for people to learn the latest developments on the trail, which sponsors believe will not only provide recreational opportunities but help to spark new economic development.

The plan is to extend the Montour Trail into Coraopolis by the old train station near Fourth

Avenue as part of the new connection, said Jack Manning, a trail council board member.

“Some sections of the trail will be paved and other sections will be made with crushed limestone. The trail will be for walking, running and biking, but there are other benefits besides recreation,” he said.

“Trails help to improve the quality of life. The most desirable homes are where people have access to trails and green space.”

The trail will stay as close to the Ohio River as possible, and access points to the river are planned. An Ohio River Water Trail is being planned in conjunction with the land trail, which the council believes will open up more opportunities for fishing, boating, bird watching and kayaking.

Part of the trail plan is also to create wetlands along the river banks near some sections of the trail to help absorb storm water runoff from communities bordering the Ohio River.

Segments of the new trail will cross brownfields, former industrial sites, in Aliquippa, Monaca, Coraopolis and Midland.

With the new recreational opportunities created by the trail, Mr. Manning said, the trail council hopes to entice people to come onto the brownfield sites, spurring business and residential developments.

“Businesses often like to locate near sites where there are recreational opportunities, and we believe the trail will help make the communities more business friendly,” he said.

Several officials from Ohio were at the open house to lend support to the trail effort.

Thomas Butch, a commissioner of the Columbiana County Park District in Ohio, said he saw firsthand how the trail helped businesses in Lisbon.

“Two bike shops have opened, and restaurants report increased business from people using the trail,” he said.

A new trail section will need to be built in Ohio to connect with the Ohio River Trail at the Ohio-Pennsylvania border. After that is completed, people will be able to use the trails in Ohio all the way to Ashtabula on the shore of Lake Erie.

“It will be one of the most scenic and heavily forested sections of the trails in Ohio,” he said.

Mr. Troia, who is CEO and executive chairman of the trail council, said work is progressing on the engineering and final design of the trail, and the council is seeking right-of-way approvals and additional funding for construction.

“We want to start at both ends and eventually meet somewhere in the middle,” he said.

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